

Siddharth Thikekar

CSE-DS

Company: Barclays

Job Profile: Technology Developer Graduate

Offer Type: Placement Only

Internship Stipend: N/A

CTC: 13.5 LPA

Location: Pune

Process Date:

OA round : 26th July 2025

PPT + Interviews - 29th July 2025

Placement Process:

1. **Online Assessment** [135 candidates appeared, 37 shortlisted]

The **online assessment** consisted of a total of **15 questions** and had a **duration of 1 hour and 30 minutes**. Among these, one was a **DSA problem of medium to hard difficulty**, and another was a relatively **easy SQL question**. The remaining **13 questions** focused on **Object-Oriented Programming (OOPs)** and **SQL concepts**. It's important to **pay close attention to the weightage of the MCQ questions**, as **each question carries a different number of points**. Make sure to **solve the higher-weightage questions carefully**, as they can often be the **deciding factor** in your overall score and selection.

The **selection criteria** to appear for the test required a **minimum CGPA of 7**. However, to **maximize your chances** of being eligible for most companies' online assessments, it is **highly recommended** to maintain a **CGPA of at least 8 or above**.

The **DSA problem** asked in the test has been **REPEATED OVER THE PAST 2-3 YEARS!!**. It is **STRONGLY ADVISED** to go through the following question beforehand:

 [LeetCode Discuss: String Generation OA Question](#)

 The **first comment contains the complete solution (Peng Cao code)** — please go through it thoroughly.

For the SQL code please go through the **Datetime functions** in SQL: [MySQL Date and Time Functions - GeeksforGeeks](#)

For additional past-year questions, you can also refer to the **JobOverflow website**.

The **OOPs questions**, generally asked in either **C++ or Java**, require a **strong foundational understanding** of core **OOP concepts**. I've shared a link below that comprehensively covers all important OOP topics.

As for the **SQL MCQ's**, although the questions were on the **easier side**, they still tested your understanding of **key concepts** like **GROUP BY** and **JOINS**. A solid grasp of these basics will be sufficient to tackle them confidently.

I was able to solve all 10 out of 10 test cases in the DSA question, which significantly boosted my chances of selection, as the problem carried a weightage of **50 points**. The SQL query question was worth **10 points**, but it's important to note that the **MCQ section also carried substantial weightage** and should not be taken lightly.

In fact, several candidates who solved only 8 out of 10 DSA test cases but performed well in the MCQs were still shortlisted. This clearly shows that a balanced performance across **both the coding and aptitude sections** is key to maximizing your chances of getting selected.

So, while solving the DSA problem is crucial, make sure to **focus equally on the MCQs**.

2. **Technical Round** [37 candidates appeared, 19 Shortlisted]

My **interview round lasted approximately 45 minutes** and was **primarily focused on my resume**. It is therefore **strongly recommended** to go through your resume **thoroughly** beforehand, as the interviewer asked me questions related to almost **every keyword** I had mentioned.

I was asked to **explain my project in detail**, including:

- What problem it solved
- The **end-to-end flow** of the project
- How I would adapt the project to **different real-world scenarios**

He also inquired about the **data storage** aspect — specifically:

- **How the data was stored in the database**
- **Whether it was hashed**, and if so,
- **Which hashing algorithm** was used

I believe this question was asked because I had mentioned a **cybersecurity internship** on my resume.

Additionally, I was asked about **JWT (JSON Web Token)** — including:

- Its **three sections**
- Some basic **code snippets** to write like `jwt.sign()` and `jwt.verify()`
- Where exactly **JWT authentication** took place in my project flow

Again, these questions were asked because **JWT** was explicitly mentioned in my resume, reinforcing the fact that the interviewer was closely referring to it.

I was also asked to write several **SQL queries**, particularly involving:

- **GROUP BY**,
- **HAVING**,
- **OFFSET**, and
- **LIMIT** clauses

He even gave me a SQL query and asked me to **predict its output**, testing both my understanding and practical knowledge.

TIPS:

1. While explaining my projects, I made a conscious effort to **relate them to real-world scenarios**—highlighting the actual problems people face and how my project aimed to solve them. This approach helped the interviewer understand the **practical impact** and **relevance** of my work.
2. During the explanation of various technical concepts, I used **numerous examples** to illustrate each point, which helped convey my **in-depth understanding** clearly. I didn't just explain *what* I used, but also *why* I used it, *why I chose it over alternatives*, and **how it benefited the project** overall. This demonstrated not only my **technical depth**, but also my **thought process** and **problem-solving mindset** during the development phase. It also reflected my **genuine passion** for building meaningful projects and thinking through every detail.
3. One of the most important things to remember during interviews is not to get intimidated by the interviewer. They're not there to scare you — they're there to evaluate you, yes, but also to help you bring out your best. Keeping your mind calm is crucial. When you're relaxed, new ideas, better explanations, and clearer thought processes naturally flow. That's when you're able to think on your feet, connect concepts, and frame your answers effectively.

I would highly recommend adopting a **similar approach** when discussing your projects—if **your interviewer is open to hearing your thought process**. In my case, the interviewer was specifically interested in understanding the reasoning behind my decisions.

That said, it's equally important to **read the interviewer's expectations**. If they prefer **direct, to-the-point answers**, then align your responses accordingly. **Adapting your communication style** based on the interviewer's cues can significantly enhance the impact of your responses.

3. **Techno-HR Round** [19 candidates appeared]

This round lasted approximately 30-40 minutes for me and focused primarily on HR-based questions. While my round didn't involve any technical questions, a few other candidates were asked some basic-level technical queries, so it's best to stay prepared for both.

The core of my round revolved around team collaboration scenarios. The interviewer asked about:

- The group sizes I've worked with,
- How I handle conflicts or disagreements in a team,
- What I would do in situations requiring leadership, adaptability, or compromise.

It became clear that the objective of this round was not only to assess how well I align with the company's core values, particularly the RISES principles, but also to understand how I approach team collaboration—a critical skill in the corporate environment where working effectively with diverse teams is essential.

In the end 16 people were offered the job!!

Useful Resources:

CS Fundamentals:

Operating Systems: [Last Minute Notes – Operating Systems - GeeksforGeeks](#)

DBMS: [Top 60 DBMS Interview Questions with Answers for 2025 - GeeksforGeeks](#)

SQL: [SQL Tutorial](#)

Additional concepts can be covered from love babbar's playlist for OS and DBMS.

DSA: [striver a-z dsa course](#)

Strivers SDE sheets can also be followed if you are familiar with the basic concepts.